

ELUSIVE AGENCY

The politicisation of terrorism and a waffling Union ministry spell doom for the proposed federal investigation agency to counter terror

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

The concept is alluring and seemingly straight out of the American TV thriller 24. An all-seeing Indian FBI which tirelessly eavesdrops on terrorist chatter, tracks them across states before finally swooping down on them. Except, like a well-worn movie cliché, the proposed Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) and its Jack Bauers are periodically brandished by the Central government as the silver bullet to combat the spectre of terrorism. Days after the Jaipur blasts, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh batted for the proposal, saying it hadn't taken off because of the "reluctance" of states to "surrender their powers".

The creation of this Central agency is an issue that has now polarised the Centre and states along political fault-lines. Congress-ruled states like Maharashtra, which suffered the worst single terror attack (the Mumbai train blasts of 2006), favour the FIA. "There should be a Central agency to investigate all terror crimes," says state police chief A.N. Roy. On the other hand, states like Gujarat and Rajasthan, ruled by the Opposition, vociferously oppose it, while Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar instead seeks greater cooperation between the Centre and states. And while the Mayawati Government has so far maintained a studied silence on the issue, state officials say they would not like a direct interference of the Centre under the garb of FIA.

First mooted by the NDA government in 2002 as an 'Indian FBI', the proposed agency was to deal with a range of inter-state crimes like terrorism. But the recent spate of terror attacks through the hinterland has given it further impetus. Each anti-terrorist

SEEKING ANSWERS:
An NSG bomb squad at a Jaipur blast site



WHAT STATES SAY ON FIA

UTTAR PRADESH

Silent. Officials say law and order is a state subject. Unhappy ceding to Central agency.

MAHARASHTRA

Says FIA is fine since "MCOCA can't control terror". Wants new terror-specific law.

RAJASTHAN

Has no objection but wants FIA to be well-defined with parameters and mandates.

GUJARAT

Says no to FIA. Fears it will be a political tool. Wants Centre to okay GUJCOC.